You may leave out the highlighted portion in the text when preparing for your exams

BRILL

JOURNAL OF THE ECONOMIC AND
SOCIAL HISTORY OF THE ORIENT 64 (2021) 302-341

JESHO

brill.com/jesh

Old Routes, New Dreams: Reminiscences of the Southern Silk Road and Bengal-China Connectivities

Jayati Bhattacharya | ORCID 0000-0001-7311-2968
Senior Lecturer, South Asian Studies Programme,
National University of Singapore, Singapore
jayati2@gmail.com

Abstract

An increasing optimism at the prospect of "shared prosperity" has revived attention on ancient historical routes such as the Southern Silk Road compelling us to rethink notions of the "centre" and the "periphery" in comprehending binaries of nation-states and agencies of globalization. This article focuses on revisiting circulatory movements and networks from the past across land and sea between Bengal delta and China in strengthening the networks and a new alignment of communities and economic possibilities. It explores some of the lesser-studied historical routes in the region and different dimensions of "place making" in the popular imagination and new synergies to redefine the Bengal-China connections.

Keywords

circulatory – connectivities – place making – Southern Silk Road – periphery

Introduction

As part of a recent wave of geopolitical developments in South Asia in the new millennium, there has been focused attention in the northern region of the Bay of Bengal, a meeting ground for India, China and Southeast Asia, and a space that has been regarded as the "periphery" both in traditional socio-political visions of India and China. A shift in eco-strategic alignments of both nation-states and new policy initiatives like India"s Look East Policy/ Act East

© KONINKLIJKE BRILL NV, LEIDEN, 2021 | DOI:10.1163/15685209-12341538
Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

Policy (LEP/ AEP) since the 1990s and China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) 2013 onwards, have invoked and energized the memories of interconnectedness between different communities, cultures and old trade routes that had prevailed for generations, but had been marginalized in the narratives of the "frontier" and the "periphery" through different periods of history. New routes has become both "geographical and a political idea, both an end and a means."[1] This article is based on long-term transitions in engagements across the landscape of the Bengal delta, Ganges and Brahmaputra valleys, Tibetan plateau, Himalayan Mountains and Arakan hills, extending to the Yunnan region of Southwest China and Indian Ocean maritime networks. It argues that the centrality of this space that can be broadly defined as "Bengal"[2] within well-connected networks that extended to China, Southeast Asia and other parts of the globe. Bengal synergized both the overland and maritime worlds through webs of ecological conditions (riverine networks, mountain agriculture, valley-dominated states, agrarian economies) and interconnectedness that served circulatory regional systems of trade and commerce, and also reached out to the Indian Ocean global networks. However, Bengal has been considered a peripheral region by different Indian dynasties that ruled northern India with the central seat of power located far from the sea. Similarly, Yunnan formed the peripheral region of the Chinese seat of governance in Peking/ Beijing. Very few alternate arguments countering the academic construct of the "periphery" have emerged from scholars like Yang Bin who has focussed on the centrality of Yunnan in the global connectedness of the Southwest Silk route, or Van Schendel"s study on the "Bengal Borderlands."[3] The fluid links bridged the connection between "Zomian" Himalayan-Tibetan highlands[4] and the Braudelian regional worlds connected by the sea.

1 M.Z. Ispahani, *Roads and Rivals: The Political Uses of Access in the Borderlands of Asia* (Ithaca and London: Cornell University Press, 1989): 2. Though Ispahani had written on the transformation of borderlands in South, West and Central Asia in the late 1980s, his observations on the close relations of routes between political, ideational, geographical and economic understanding is relevant in our discussion on the northern Bay of Bengal region.

2 In this paper, Bengal refers to the region mostly covering the modern states of Bangladesh and West Bengal, India. Geographically, it joins the Himalayan mountain belt with the river systems traversing through its land and the deltaic space before it reaches the sea, thus synergizing different communication and transport networks with communities, commodities, culture and polities. The terms Bengal, Bengal delta, Tibet, Tibetan highlands, and Yunnan, as mentioned in the article, are more directed to their geographical and spatial imagery. They were in no ways static expressions and constantly changed their territorialities over time.

3 Bin Yang, "Horses Silver, Cowries: Yunnan in Global Perspective." *Journal of World History* 15/3 (September 2004): 281-322; W. Van Schendel, *The Bengal Borderland: Beyond State and Nation in South Asia* (London: Anthem Press, 2005).

4 James C. Scott used the idea of 'Zomia' for the vast expanse of about 2.5 million square kilometers of highlands between Vietnam and northeast India, see J.C. Scott, *The Art of Not Being*

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

In the process of invoking the ancient global socio-economic networks, the South Silk Road has often been overwhelmed by the Central Asian Silk Route and/ or the Maritime Silk Road discourses. Also, the "Silk Route' was not one dominant route but rather a well-established web of several pathways and corridors across land, river and sea[5] forming an overlap of the Southern Silk Route, Southwest Silk Route (from the perspectives of China) or alternately, the Cotton Road. What has been marginalized in political-academic discourses is the circularity and interconnectedness of the overland, riverine and the maritime connectivities between China, South and Southeast Asia and beyond; such circularity and interconnectedness exposes the centrality of "Bengal" in the continuing rhetoric of India-China connections. The diverse ecological, political and economic systems that shaped Bengal through different time periods have been, as argued by scholars like Tirthankar Roy, too fragmented and different for a meaningful notion of Bengal to emerge. In place of such a notion, Roy considers early modern Bengal as a "series of parallel globalizations" of "resources, trade costs, and increasingly ambitious fiscal state, itinerant merchants, and military adventurers."[6] On a micro-level, this segmented understanding of Bengal may be useful; here, Roy's argument is not on claims of homogeneity of identical spaces in Bengal, but rather the emphasis is on linkages and interconnectedness in diversities that extended Bengal's arms regionally and globally. In spite of the existence of numerous polities in the region with different political governance, and the difficulties of river navigation in Brahmaputra and Meghna, we find strong evidences of the common economic inward flow of silver and horses,[7] establishment of several mints circulating silver coins in the early medieval economy, global popularity of Bengal's products like textiles, and regional circulation of cowries since the

Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009). Willem van Schendel extended it further to the Himalayas and the Tibetan highlands. See his "Geographies of knowing, geographies of ignorance: jumping scale in Southeast Asia." *Environment and Planning D: Society and Space* 20 (2002): 647-68.

5 Scholars have often debated the existence of a historical highway between Assam and China through Myanmar. Haraprasad Ray discussed the arguments of several scholars like P.C. Bagchi, T.C. Sharma, Joseph Needham, Nayanjot Lahiri and others. See H. Ray, "Southern Silk Route: A Perspective." In *The Southern Silk Route: Historical Links and Contemporary Convergences*, ed. Lipi Ghosh (New Delhi: Manohar, 2019): 31.

6 T. Roy, "Where is Bengal? Situating an Indian Region in the Early Modern Period." *Past and Present* 213 (November 2011): 121. Roy also uses the trope of ballads and other Bengali literary works to bring out the differences between the socio-cultural understanding of eastern and western Bengal.

7 S.E. Hussain, "Silver Flow and Horse Supply to Sultanate Bengal with Special Reference to Trans-Himalayan Trade (13th-16th Centuries)." *Journal of Economic and Social History of the Orient* 56/2 (2013): 264-308; R. Chakravarti, "Early Medieval Bengal and the Trade in Horses: A Note." *Journal of Economic and Social History of the Orient* 42/2 (1999): 194-211.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

ancient period that reiterates Bengal's significance in a macro-level regional and global context. These spatialities and the temporalities since the ancient period allow for a lesser-known itineraries of merchants and their networks that, one may argue, were in no way peripheral. The dynamism of the geographical features presented by the extended fluvial system of South-Southeast Asia, allied with well-knit Himalayan trade routes, river systems and ports of the Bay of Bengal, opens up the region for greater scrutiny for its interconnectedness and posits it as an important economic and cultural nodal points within the circle of interrelated histories.

1 Between Space and Time

Propounded by the economic and societal conjectures of *longue durée* by Fernand Braudel, the "precise idea of the multiplicity of temporalities and of the exceptional importance of the long term,"[8] may be relatable to the arguments on the spatial history and identity formation of "Bengal." This article makes long leaps through periodic/"episodic" histories,[9] argues the massive impacts of the complex historical processes, both linear and non-linear that cut across space and time. In Bengal's "episodic" histories, continuity of economic activities like significant role of commodities and merchants, external and internal trade circuits have played an equally important role in the formation and survival of political power structures and their religious inclinations as in the domains of culture and identity. Buddhism spread under the Mauryan rule and flourished under the Pala kings between 3rd and the 7th-8th CE. Many archeological sites in modern West Bengal (India) and Bangladesh bear significant footprints of this religion that had once prospered.[10] The Sena kings, who followed the Palas, reinstated a reformed Brahmanical religion that witnessed the co-existence of Shaivism, Vaishnavism and the indigenous Goddess cults. From the 14th century onwards, Bengal, which had by then witnessed the extension of Muslim rule from Delhi, came under the rule of Shams al-Dil Ilyas Shahi (1342-57). He marked the break from the centralized authority of Delhi

8 F. Braudel, "History and the Social Sciences—The Longue Durée" (translated by Immanuel Wallerstein). *Review* 32/2 (2009): 173.

9 Ibid.: 174. Braudel refers to Francois Simiand, who uses the term "episodic history" in writing about short-term political history reflective of great events.

10 Some Buddhist religious sites that still exist are Sompur Vihara (Rajshahi district), Salban Vihara (Mainamati), Mahasthanagarh (Bogra-Rangpur area) in Bangladesh and Tamralipti (or Tamluk in Midnapore district), Raktamrittika Mahavihara (Gauda, Malda district), Chandraketugarh (North 24 Paraganas district) and Mogalmari (Midnapore district) in West Bengal, India. Xuang Zhang, the Chinese monk, visited Tamralipti in 639 CE.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

with the shift of the Shahi capital from Lakhnauti to Pandua.[11] It was a significant political expression "of a long present cultural autonomy" that continued undisturbed for almost two centuries.[12]

To use space as an analytical tool in understanding society (in this case, "Bengal"), as does Lefebvre,[13] it is often imagined as a means of production akin to commodities, money and capital. Space is also a means of control and domination but yet not completely mastered by social and political state forces. Space also enables various modes of production, which is then dependent on several factors. Bengal's cotton, amongst other products, was widely acclaimed and had extensive regional and global markets. The connecting commercial interactions also extended to Yunnan in Southwest China, up north into the Tibetan highlands and across the maritime routes to Southeast Asia, West Asia, and China, as we shall discuss in a later section. In thinking about Bengal's outward mobility, one could also relate to the idea of transnationalism in terms of memory space as Green explores the Muslim communities through shrine building, writing of texts, and creating new sacred geographies—geographies of memory, belonging and power.[14] At the same time, the region has been identified with several frontiers in different narratives created over different periods of time, as argued in Richard Eaton's idea of spatial construct of frontiers—political, Islamic and agrarian (between 13th to 18th centuries)—"Bengal was the terminus of a continent wide process of Turko-Mongol conquest and migration. It was in short, a frontier zone."[15] Many medieval foreign travellers and court chroniclers have reiterated the peripheral construct of Bengal in their narratives. In the late thirteenth century, Marco Polo describes "Bangala" as a place that was "tolerably close to India" and its people speaking a "peculiar language". Abul-fazl Allami, Akbar's chief advisor, paints a picture (in *Akbar-namah*) of Bengal as Bulghakkhana (house of turbulence) where "the dust of dissension is always rising". In *Ain-i-Akbari*, Allami resonates with Ibn Battuta (who was a guest of the Central Asian Sufi saint Shah Jalal in Sylhet in 1345 CE) to describe north Bengal and Assam as mysterious and magical.[16] The prevailing impressions, coupled with the region's unique ecology, created a distinct spatiality for Bengal that energized it with an autonomous

11 R.M. Eaton, *The Rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier, 1204-1760* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1993).

12 Ibid.: 41.

13 H. Levebvre, *The Production of Space* (Translated by D. Nicholson-Smith), (Oxford, Cambridge: Blackwell Publishing, 1991).

14 N. Green, *Making Space: Sufis and Settlers in Early Modern India*. (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2012): 11.

15 Eaton. *The Rise of Islam*: xxiii.

16 Ibid.: 41, 77, 168.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

identity extending beyond the alignments of centralized political authority based in and around Delhi. If this autonomy endorsed exclusive "frontier" distinctiveness for Bengal, it also facilitated its independent global interactions. When the Ming court in China directed seven naval expeditions to the Indian Ocean, two of these expeditions arrived in Pandua (1415) and Gaur (1432).[17] Bengal also became closely linked with the geographically contiguous Arakan region of Burma linguistically, religiously and culturally—an association that has been reflected in ballad traditions of east Bengal, several Bengali literary compositions as well as in British reports and narratives.[18]

The British colonial footsteps of aggression and acquisition started in Bengal after the Battle of Plassey (1757) and the Battle of Buxar (1764). They would eventually build the foundation of an Empire for the next two centuries out of Calcutta, a city that soon attained a global status of the "London of the East". Though Britain's conquests enabled her to foster Bengal's prosperity and fame on a global level, the structural and administrative changes as well as the Western-centric narratives brought about by the long years of British domination reframed the changing forms of interactions of Bengal (that was divided twice)[19] that it had with its neighbours, thus creating disruptions in several centuries of accommodations and interactions. It was also during the convergence of Asian and Imperial forces in the colonial 19th century that, as is also reiterated by David Ludden, "Asian geography in general acquired its modern territorial framework…."[20] Ludden visualizes the Second World war as the moment of "a sharp break" in the history of the Meghna-Brahmaputra river basin[21] between Burma, China, India and Tibet. However, the new colonial administrative units that had been set up, the trade routes and commercial centres that had developed and political boundaries that were drawn

17 Ibid.: 49.

18 Swapna Bhattacharya (Chakraborti), "Myth and History of Bengali Identity in Arakan" in Jos Gommans and Jacques Leider eds. *The Maritime Frontier of Burma: Exploring Political, Cultural and Commercial Interaction in the Indian Ocean World, 1200-1800* (Leiden: KILTV Press, 2002): 199-212.

19 The first Partition of Bengal, as initiated by the British in 1905 on the ostensible reason of necessity of such a division for administrative purposes (but actually divided on the Hindu and Muslim majority population), could not endure due to huge protests from different corners of the society. The second Partition was a permanent one in 1947 resulting in unabated violence and mass killings and destruction that divided the Indian subcontinent into India and Pakistan (West and East Pakistan). Bangladesh was formed in 1971 when East Pakistan claimed and secured recognition as a separate entity.

20 D. Ludden, "India's Spatial History in the Brahmaputra-Meghna River Basin." In *Landscape, Culture and Belonging: Writing the History of Northeast India*, ed. N. Bhattacharya and J. Pachuau (Cambridge, New York: Cambridge University Press, 2019): 25.

21 Ibid.: 26.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

by the colonists, had already marked a break from the past and led to appropriation and confining people within differently formed boundaries. Political restructuring led to shifts in the paradigms from fluid exchanges across communities and polities to forming more structured and Western-centric future nation-state discourses, memories of space and spatial metaphors, creating distinctions between people and civilizations which led to long-term repercussions in situating Bengal/ India's position with its eastern and northern contiguities.

With the churn of revised policy initiatives in the new millennium, "spheres of influence," "frontier states" and "peripheral regions" are being renegotiated and encountered between the rising Asian giants, India and China. The political discourse has steered from nation-state centricism and territoriality to a more diffusive and influential extension of the states' arms into the maritime domain. If the "Beijing Consensus" has gained global currency, so has India's more regional and non-assertive "Act East" approach. Both states have displayed significant shift in their templates of policy-making to be more inclusive of peripheral regions, thus creating a sense of overlap between the eastern "periphery" of India and the southwestern "frontiers" of China. Quite contrary to the strained political relations between India and China, each trying to focus on their individual geo-strategic visions, Bangladesh has been heavily inclined in favour of China's aid and investments in different sectors and is presently the second-largest recipient of China's loans under the BRI project.[22] On the other hand, India (and thus, West Bengal) has refrained from joining the BRI projects. This situation has brought into prominence the conflicting responses by different states in and around the space of "Bengal" with different considerations of the alignments with either of the Asian giants in present policy matters.

In Immanuel Wallerstein's conceptual model of the global capitalist economy, South Asia remained as a "semi-periphery" of the world-system.[23]

22 China and Bangladesh signed nine agreements covering different sectors in 2019. China is Bangladesh's largest trading partner, and had been eyeing to make huge investments in upgrading Chittagong port facilities that would link Kunming in the Yunnan province to South-Southeast Asian region and access the maritime frontiers in northern Bay of Bengal. China has also built eight friendship bridges across the river, Padma. Sudha Ramachandran, "How Bangladesh Learned to Love the Belt and Road." *The Diplomat*, 22 July 2019, https://thediplomat.com/2019/07/how-bangladesh-learned-to-love-the-belt-and-road/ accessed 14 July 2020.

23 Immanuel Wallerstein's world-system divides the world into core, semi-peripheral and peripheral regions on the basis of the transnational division of labour. The core regions have capital-intensive production with higher skills, while the rest are labour-intensive, low-skilled countries and suppliers of resources. For further details, refer to

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

David Washbrook criticized this argument and highlighted "core" features of a South Asia that, he argued, constituted neither "periphery" nor "semi-periphery."[24] Historians like C.A. Bayly and David Ludden supported Washbrook's critique. Ludden criticized the Eurocentric formulation of Wallerstein's ideas of the world-system,[25] while Bayly highlighted different levels of local economic-political activities of the sub-continent as it was appropriated into the global capitalist economy.[26] These historians have structured their arguments under the conventional spatial imagination of South Asia, a post-colonial historical construction that emanated from American area studies programmes during the Cold War period and continues to prevail in academic scholarship. These interpretations of economic and political systems were heavily rooted in the notion of territorial acquisitions, which coincided with the centrality of the main political seat of power in the "heartland" region for different governing regimes in history, thus pushing the sub-Himalayan regions and their global connections through a web of complex fluvial morphology and maritime frontiers as the "periphery."

Interdisciplinary scholarship on Asian borderlands, the Indian Ocean Region and transnational communities has interrupted the rigid walls of area demarcations; however, fluid interactions of diverse identities of space, polities and communities remain significant challenges of "place making." The idea of a "Bengal borderland," as Van Schendel defines the boundaries between India, Bangladesh and Myanmar, constitutes a way of re-conceptualizing the

---

Immanuel M. Wallerstein, *Historical Capitalism* (London: Verso, 1983), *World-Systems Analysis: An Introduction* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2004), and "Systems Analysis and Historical Particularity: Some Comments." In *South Asia and World Capitalism,* ed. S. Bose (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1990): 21-26.

24 D.A. Washbrook, "South Asia, World System and World Capitalism." *Journal of Asian Studies* 49/3 (1990): 479-508. Washbrook discusses ideas such as the strong state, robust financial structure, industry and the dynamic presence of the bourgeoisie that could not resonate with the concept of 'periphery.'

25 David Ludden, "World Economy and Village India, 1600-1900." In *South Asia and World Capitalism,* ed. Sugata Bose (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1990): 162-163.

26 C.A. Bayly, "Indigenous Social Formations and the 'World System': North India since c. 1700." In *South Asia and World Capitalism* ed. Sugata Bose (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1990): 112-139. Earlier, Bayly had elaborated on the interactions and the layers of different economic activities in northern India. C.A. Bayly, *Rulers, Townsmen and Bazaars: North Indian Society in the Age of British Expansion, 1770-1870* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983). This debate between the scholars of South Asia has been highlighted and discussed by Abikal Borah in his work on the northeast. See A. Borah, "A Region in a Mobile World: Integration of Southeastern Himalayan Region into the Global Capitalist Economy (1820-1900)." *Review* 37/2 (2014): 87-127.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

socio-political space after 1947.[27] On the other hand, Joya Chatterji questions the Radcliffe Line (boundary line dividing Bengal and East Pakistan in 1947) on the "tangible geopolitical reality" from the ground.[28] The Line drawn up with supposed precision continued the transnational flow of migrants and refugees, and the trade in goods and exchange of information giving rise to continued stories of struggle and powers of territorial control, whether it was India-Bangladesh refugee crisis on the west (of Bangladesh) or displaced communities of the Rohingyas, Shan on the east. However, the pursuit of territoriality has transitioned to "a new phase of territorialisation" where the bond between sovereignty and territory has become partially "unbundled" with increasing globalization.[29] In re-conceptualizing the spatial landscape in the new millennium, an intimate connection between the land and maritime domain has emerged as a significant function of state narratives (like India's Act East policy, or the Belt and Road initiative by China), which draw heavily from the historical maritime connections and trade circuits within Asia and across the globe, however, the interactions are regulated by nation-state boundaries. The imagination of Indian Ocean interactions in academic and policy discourses have assumed an important role in rethinking about the centrality of the northern Bay (West Bengal, Northeastern India, Bangladesh, Burma) and its connections with China. Though several scholars have already worked on the maritime routes between India, Southeast Asia and China, their scholarship mostly focused either on pre-colonial connections, or on the present geopolitics, and thus mostly "episodic" approach rather than linking up the continuities.

The transitional and multi-ethnic nature of the trading diasporas across the Bay[30] that were fluid and largely voluntary in the pre-colonial period, hindered long-term rootings in any visible scale. At a later period, these diasporas were largely framed within European colonial encounters creating new boundaries, mobilities and fixities to fit into the global political-economic necessities. In the disruptions and altering landscapes of place making, India and China were posited against each other, in the rhetoric of the "supplier" and "consumer" of

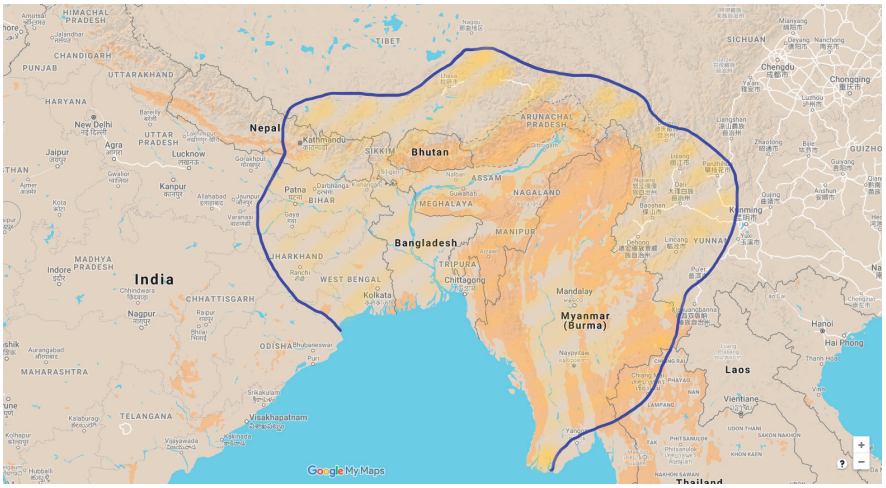
27 van Schendel, *The Bengal Borderland*: 2.

28 J. Chatterji, "The Fashioning of a Frontier: The Radcliffe Line and Bengal's Border Landscape, 1947-52." *Modern Asian Studies* 33/1 (February 1999): 185-242.

29 Van Schendel, *Bengal Borderland*: 6.

30 Historians working on the period between twelfth to fifteenth centuries like Kenneth Hall and Tansen Sen have emphasized on this, see K.R. Hall, "Ports-of-Trade, Maritime Diasporas, and Networks of Trade and Cultural Integration in the Bay of Bengal Region of the Indian Ocean: c. 1300-1500." *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 53/1-2 (2010): 109-45; T. Sen, "The Formation of Chinese Maritime Networks to Southern Asia, 1200-1450." *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 49/4 (2006): 421-53.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library



MAP 1 Centrality of Bengal in India-China connections in the northern Bay [The boundary not drawn to scale]

opium and tea, both feeding into Britain's coffers. As the colonial trajectories gained ground, the centrality of Bengal still remained, primarily as the seat of British political and economic power and main conduits of transactions with the East. New borders and networks of roads, railways, ports restructured India-China interactions that had long lasting legacy on nurturing mutual perceptions. Bengal also became home, in Calcutta, to India's largest "China Town", which still survives as a unique space for the Chinese diaspora[31] where Chinese maintained their distinct identity along with incorporating the local language, culture, religious beliefs and practices. (There is a Chinese Kali

31 One of the lesser-studied aspects of the colonial period is the diasporic connections (other than labour mobilities) and circulation of ideas between diverse groups of people, particularly from Bengal. Thus, while Calcutta was the home of the largest 'China Town' in India, Bengali intellectuals and political leaders were reaching out to the Chinese counterparts in various capacities. A broad view of this circulation has been addressed in Jayati Bhattacharya, "Connectivity Across Colonial Bay of Bengal in the 19th and 20th Centuries." In David Ludden Ed., *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Asian History,* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2019). oxfordre.com/asianhistory. Lesser-studied trade diasporas and business communities have been taken up in a research in, Jayati Bhattacharya, *Beyond the Myth: Indian Business Communities in Singapore* (Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, 2011). Besides, other works on Indian Ocean circulation by Sugata Bose [*A Hundred Horizons: The Indian Ocean in the Age of the Global Empire* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 2006)] and the labour circulation from South India across the Bay by Sunil Amrith [*Crossing the Bay of Bengal: The Furies of Nature and Fortunes of Migrants* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 2013)] deserve special mention.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

Temple dedicated to the popular Hindu goddess, in Kolkata's China Town) Contemporary state-led projects have attempted to revive many of these tangible and intangible heritage linkages as a soft power tool in diplomatic activities with a new garb of transnational/ transregional connections, but that which fits well within the individual state's policy narratives. However, that agenda-driven revival of historical engagements has not always been very successful.

2 Commodities, Routes and Networks: Pre-colonial Phase

The various links and trade routes that existed in the pre-colonial phase may be categorized into four major economic corridors:

a. Tibet-Bhutan-Nepal-Bengal links
b. Yunnan-Arakan-Bengal route
c. Gangetic valley riverine networks and commercial centres
d. Kamarupa-Bengal links

Tibet, Nepal and Bhutan had reciprocally favourable trade relations with Bengal for most of the ancient and medieval period and provided important pathways for their products to be transported to the deltaic ports and to other destinations beyond South Asia. Generally speaking, governance of Tibet and Nepal (under the Newars until the more assertive Gurkhas took over) were favourable to inter-regional trade and commercial activities. The *Periplus* (1st Century CE) mentioned vigorous exchange of commodities across the Himalayas, past Sikkim and Chumbi Valley to Tibet and China, and materials like raw silk, silk yarn and cloths to Bengal from China that were re-exported to Dammirriea through the Ganges.[32] Between Kamrupa and Tibet, there were thirty-five mountain passes through which horses were brought into Lakhnauti in Bengal.[33] Tibet also traded in rich minerals like gold, rock salt, tinsel, coral, musk, and wool. Indian spices, salt, embroidery, silk cloth, brocades, saffron, sandalwood, indigo, cotton seed, jewellery, perfumes and drugs[34] were traded with Nepal in return for herbs, hides, certain metal goods, musk, yak tails, wool, elephant tusks, timber bronze, and items of religious and artistic value.[35]

The Yunnan-Arakan-Bengal route was another important conduit in trade and cultural exchanges between India and China. Yang Bin has highlighted the

32 R.C. Mazumdar, *History of Bengal*, Volume-1 (Dacca: University of Dacca, 1976): 663.
33 Ibid.
34 J. Sen, *Indo-Nepal Trade in the Nineteenth Century* (Firma KLM Private Limited: Calcutta, 1977): 16-18.
35 Ibid.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

links of Southwest China to the Bay of Bengal—important nodes of connections were Yongchang (Baoshan) and Tencheng.[36] Equally important centres of trade were Bhamo and Myitkyana in Burma that linked India in the west and Yunnan in China in the east through interlinking caravan-river routes.[37] The Brahmaputra, like the Ganges, connected both land and river routes passing through Sadiya, Kapili (present Nowgong), Pragjyotishpura (Guwahati), Hadapeswara (Tezpur) and Davaka. Guwahati, the capital of Kamarupa, was a flourishing centre of commerce and a trans-shipment node for exchange of goods by both land and water. Another route from Tonkin to Kamarupa moved across the Karatoya river and passed by Pundravardhana, then across the Ganges to Magadha. From various points in Bengal, a network of highways converged to Benaras, thus linking the road to Bodh Gaya, the Buddhist pilgrimage site.[38]

P.C. Bagchi, one of the earliest Sinologists in post-independent India, worked extensively on Chinese accounts of trade routes from eastern India to Yunnan.

> This trade route started from Yunanfu (that is, present-day Kunming), the capital of Yunnan province, crossed the hilly country and present-day Shan kingdom and ended at Bhamo.... There were two land-routes for reaching India viz. one through the northeastern part of Assam and another through Arakan and Manipur. Both the routes met at Pataliputra, the capital of Magadha, the final destination.[39]

The Silk Roads started taking shape by the end of the first Century BCE when the Han dynasty in China occupied parts of Central Asia and significantly

36 Yang Bin, *Between Winds and Clouds: The Making of Yunnan* (*Second Century BCE to Twentieth Century CE*) (New York: Columbia University Press, 2009).

37 Lipi Ghosh describes the caravan routes from Bhamo in Burma to Yunnan connecting the navigable territories of the Irrawaddy. Bhamo was an important conduit for trade transactions with a heterogeneous population comprising the Chinese, Kachin and Shan traders. In the early nineteenth century, these routes that carried jade, rubies, amber, ivory, silver and other luxuries to China, became significant areas of contestations between the British and the French, who were also interested in items like silk and tea. See, L. Ghosh, *Burma: Myth of French Intrigue* (Calcutta: Naya Udyog, 1994):104-131.

38 For further references on trans-Himalayan trade, see R. Sarkar and I. Roy, "Two Nineteenth Century Trade Routes in the Eastern Himalayas: The Bhutanese Trade with Tibet and Bengal." *Journal of Bhutan Studies* 15 (Winter 2006): 56-83; Ratna Sarkar and Indrajit Ray, "Political Scenario in Bhutan during 1774-1906: An Impact Analysis on Trade and Commerce." *Journal of Bhutan Studies* 17 (Winter 2007):1-20.

39 Bangwei Wang and Tansen Sen compiled *India and China: Interactions through Buddhism and Diplomacy—A Collection of Essays by Professor Prabodh Chandra Bagchi* (New Delhi: Anthem Press, 2011): 206.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

integrated the Chinese Empire and expanded cross-continental interactions. The extension of Roman rule to the eastern Mediterranean and Egypt and the earlier Greek invasion of Alexander the Great, stretching into the Indian sub-continent brought closer Euro-Asian connections. The Kushan Empire (1st to 4th century CE) extending from Afghanistan to eastern India contributed to strengthening of commercial and cultural links across the continents.[40]

The Southern Silk routes stretched from the Tibetan mountains to the Bay of Bengal into Southeast Asia and also further extended to present day Guangzhou (Guangdong province) and Hepu in China. In the east, overland connectivity joined Burma (Myanmar) and Yunnan province extending into Sichuan province of China. In the west, the routes extended to the Gangetic commercial belt and river systems as well as maritime links connecting the ports of Bengal. Thus, an important intermediate zone in the larger network of South China Sea-Pacific Ocean in the East to the Mediterranean in the West flourished. It was characterized by inter-dependent commercial and cultural synergies, often facilitated by royal patronage and diplomatic missions. A large part of this transmission took place through religion and culture, through Buddhist scholar monks like Hiuen Tsang, Yijing, Faxien. Reference to China as *Cina* is found in the Indian epic, *Mahabharata* and as *Cinasi* and *Cinapatta* in early Indian texts like Kautilya's *Arthasastra*. However, most of our knowledge on India-China relations is based on various Chinese records. An account by the Chinese envoy, Zhang Qian, who was sent to India in 136 BC, mentions that India had trade relations with China before the 2nd century BC.[41]

Taking a chronological leap forward to more than sixteen centuries later, several political missions and trade interactions between Bengal and China in the fifteenth century mentioned in different Chinese sources suggest a dynamic momentum and continuity in these inter-connections. Bengal under the Muslim rulers had political and commercial connections with Chinese rulers. The Chinese sources identify the languages of the region as P'eng-kie-li (Bengali) and Persian, and prevalence of both Hindus and Muslims in the population. A rough sketch of Bengal is drawn in the table (Table :1) below from various accounts given in Chinese sources.

40 Yeuzhi (the ruling branch of the Kushanas) and Roman traders were among the most active along the connecting routes from China through the Red and the Mediterranean Sea into the Roman Empire. Tansen Sen and Victor H. Mair, *Traditional China in Asian and World History*, (Ann Arbor: Association of Asian Studies, 2012): 29-35.

41 Bangwei Wang and Tansen Sen compiled, *India China: Interactions through Buddhism and Diplomacy.*

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

TABLE 1 Chinese sources of information on Bengal in 15th-16th centuries

	Records	Information
1	*Ying yai sheng lan* compiled by Ma Huan (between 1425 and 1432)	Population dense, wealth and prosperity abundant and great. Travelling by sea from Su-men-ta-la (Sumatra) and Ma-shan, Tsui-lan islands (Nicobar) are sighted—travelling for another 20 days one arrived at Che-ti-kiang (Chittagong). Language used—P"ang-kie-li (Bengali) and Pa-eul-si (Farsi/Persian). Silver coin called Tangka was used, there was a variety of cotton fabrics for trade (*pi-pu*, *pi-po*, *man-che-ti*, *sha-na-pa-fu*, *pu-lo*, *Sha-ta-eul* (Chadar), *tu-lo-kin*)
2	*Sing ch'a sheng lan* compiled by Fei-sin (1436 AD)	This country can be reached from Sumatra with a favourable wind in 20 days. The country has a port called Ch"a-ti-kiang (Chittagong), further up is Suo-na-eul-kiang (Sonargaon) a trading centre. Pan-tu-wa (Pandua) is the capital where the ruler resides. A place with fertile soil—some natural products are cotton cloths (muslins), sa-ha-la, rugs, tu-lo-kin, rock crystal, agate, amber, pearls, precious stones, sugar, ghee, etc. The goods used by Chinese to trade are gold, silver, satins, silks, blue and white porcelain, copper, iron, musk, vermillion, quick silver, grass mats.
3	*Si yang ch'ao kung tien lu* complied by Huang Sing-ts'eng (1520 AD)	Country to the north of Nicobar (Tsui-ian) islands at a distance about 7000 li. From Sumatra and Nicobar, port of Ch"a-ti-kiang is 20 days. They use betel nuts to entertain visitors; rulers are Mahomedans, language-Bengali and Persian. Tiger play is appreciated in public. They use silver coin called tangka or sea-shells called cowrie. Description of different cotton products and Bengal is considered rich and civilized.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

TABLE 1 Chinese sources of information (*cont.*)

	Records	Information
4	***Shu yu chou tseu lu*** complied by Yen Ts'ong-kien (1574)	Bengal is identified with ancient province of Sin-tu (India), eastern Yin-tu (Indies) country. Tsa-ti-kiang (Catigaon) is at the mouth of the sea where merchants of foreign countries come. Chinese emissary Houhien carried gifts for the ruler in 1115 AD The king ceremoniously gifted them with precious presents in gold and gemstones. Tributes were horses, saddles of gold, silver and other metals, etc. The products for trade were cotton cloths, sa-ha-lo (shawl), woolen carpets, tu-lo-kin, pearls and precious stones.
5	***Ming-she*** completed in 1739- the chapter on Wai kuo chuan was compiled by You T'ung (1618-1704)	Bengal in Eastern India can be reached from Sumatra within 20 days. In the 6th year Yong-lo (1408) Ghiyas-ud-din, king of Bengal, sent ambassador to China with tributes and returned with many gifts from China as well. In the 7th year Yong-lo (1409) their ambassador came with 230 officers. Diplomatic exchanges continued. In 1438, k'i-lin (African giraffe, p.123) was sent as present.

SOURCE: AS MENTIONED IN BANGWEI WANG AND TANSEN SEN COMPILED *INDIA AND CHINA: INTERACTIONS THROUGH BUDDHISM AND DIPLOMACY—A COLLECTION OF ESSAYS BY PROFESSOR PRABODH CHANDRA BAGCHI*, (NEW DELHI: ANTHEM PRESS, 2011): 109-135.

Several products from Bengal circulated internally, regionally and globally. Some of the most popular products and currencies in trade circulation were silver (mainly imported in Bengal in the early medieval to about sixteenth century CE), horses (imported through trans-Himalayan routes), cotton textiles (exported to China, Southeast Asia and other parts of the world) and cowries (prevalent more during the Pala and Sena rule than the Bengal Sultanate or Mughal period and circulated in Pegu, Siam, Yunnan, Burma, etc.). By the way of case studies, in the pages that follow, I shall focus in some detail on the production and distribution of two commodities, cotton textiles and cowries, the latter an important medium of exchange that reflected on the routes they followed in Bengal-China interactions.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

Cotton Textiles

The records of commercial interactions between Bengal and China in the Yuan and Ming periods mention native Bengal products like *tu-lo mien* (a variety of fine cotton) and other common cotton products, and the use of white conch shells (cowries) as money. One important source from the Yuan period, *Tao yi che leo* (A Description of the Barbarian of the Isles) written around 1349-50 AD by Wang Ta-yuan, who visited Bengal, described the place thus: "The seasons of Heaven have scattered the Wealth of the Earth over this kingdom the riches and integrity of its people surpass, perhaps, those of Ch'iu-chiang (Palembang) and equal those of Chao-wa (Java)."[42] Various products of Bengal like paper, lacquer, sugar, cotton and silk, cotton and several varieties of cotton fabrics have been mentioned in Chinese sources, and many of them, according to Bagchi, have not been identified. The six different categories that are mentioned in the texts are as in the table (Table: 2) below.

The exchange of textile products between India and China in the pre-colonial phase offers evidence that that India had its independent technology of cotton (and silk) manufacturing and, also that China continued to use Indian cotton textiles long after its own discovery of the crop. Stephen F. Dale summarises the interactions quite well.

> … certain kinds of Indian cotton cloth continued to be sold in China well after the Chinese cultivation of cotton and production of cotton cloth blossomed in the late thirteenth and early fourteenth centuries…. cotton cloth was first manufactured in South Asia, where Indians continued to produce certain varieties that always found a market in China. And the knowledge of silk and cotton cultivation was transmitted to India and China, respectively, both via the so-called "Silk Road" routes of Central Asia as well as the southeast overland route that linked Szechwuan and the Chinese heartland with Burma, Assam, Bengal and the Ganges valley.[43]

Chinese sources described different trade routes between China and Arakan, Assam, Bengal delta. Some names in the Chinese sources, as pointed out by Yang, are *Nanfang Sichouzhilu* (South Silk Road), *Xi'nan Sichouzhilu* (Southwest Silk Road), *Dian-Mian-Yin Gudao* (Ancient Roads Connecting Yunnan, Burma and India), *Shu-Yandu dao* (The Road between Sichuan and India), and

42 Bangwei Wang and Tansen Sen compiled *India and China: Interactions*: 111.

43 S.F. Dale, "Silk Road, Cotton Road or…. Indo-Chinese Trade in Pre-European Times." *Modern Asian Studies* 43/1 (2009): 80.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

TABLE 2 Cotton products as identified from different Chinese sources

	Name of cotton products in Chinese	Description in different Chinese sources
1.	*Pi-pu* or *pi-po*	Different colours, fine and glossy. Dimension: 3″×56″ (one account), *Pi-pu* may be Cantonese *pat-pou* suggesting bafta- the general Persian name for cotton products. Ibn Batuta identified it with *betteela*.
2.	*Man-che-t'i*	Yellow cotton material, closely woven and strong. Dimension: 4″×50″. Tavernier mentions it as painted cloth also known as *calmendar* (*kalamdar*)
3.	*Sha-na-pa-fu*	Identified with Persian *Shanbaft*, or cotton gauze. Dimension: 30″×5″.
4.	*K'i-pai-lei-ta* *K'i-pai-k'in-ta-li*	*K"in-ta-li* stands for *chanter* (Bengali *chadar*), loosely woven, coarse cotton, maybe used as cotton gauze. Dimension: 60 feet in length
5.	*Sha-ta-eul*	Material used for turbans, similar to *chadar*. Dimension: 40″×5″/ 21/2″×4″
6.	*Ma-hei-ma-lei*	Perhaps same as *Tu-lo-kin*/*Tu-lo-mein* identified with Malmal. *Tu-lo* is transcript from Sanskrit word *tula* (cotton)—fine cotton material.

SOURCE: COLLATED FROM BANGWEI WANG AND TANSEN SEN COMPILED *INDIA AND CHINA:* 2011: 121-122.

also *Shubuzhilu* (The Road of the Shu Cloth).[44] The information reflected India-China links through the Yunnan-Arakan-Bengal routes as mentioned above. Thus, the idea of the "Cotton Road" was already familiar to Chinese travelers and scholars which may have inspired the suggestion of Dale. The different qualities and colour of cotton available[45] in Bengal, as documented in Chinese sources, revealed the popularity and demand of the cotton products in China and other parts of the globe. However, in global recognition, Richthofen was the first to name the "Silk Road"[46] and thus give it "a permanent identity

44 Yang Bin, "Horses Silver, Cowries": 284.
45 Bangwei Wang and Tansen Sen compiled *India and China: Interactions.*
46 The German geographer, Ferdinand von Richthofen coined the term 'Silk Road' in 1877. Daniel C. Waugh, "The Silk Roads in History." *Expedition* 52/3 (2010): 9.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

in the Western narrative." The conception of a Silk Road was also facilitated by the fact that silk was used as a medium of exchange along these routes. On the other hand, the name "Cotton route," though recognized by the Chinese sources and also a popular product globally, did not gain similar significance, perhaps due to the imagination of Bengal as a merely peripheral zone in prevalent historiography.

Cowries

The circulation of cowries[47] provides us with fascinating tales of conduits of exchanges across different parts of South and Southeast Asia and China. Drawing on both Chinese and non-Chinese sources,[48] scholars like Vogel,[49] Heimann[50] and Yang give us detailed accounts of cowries as medium of exchange in common markets in the region of the Bay of Bengal leading us to revisit exchanges across different geographies. Faxian (4th-5th century CE) in India (during the reign of Chandragupta II), Xuanzhang (mid-7th century) as well as Yijing (7th-8th century CE) mention the use of cowries. The term *kaoli* (derived from *kauri* in Bengali) indicating its South Asian origin, was found in the Chinese records for the first time during the Yuan-Ming period. Ibn Battuta mentions the cowrie trade between the Maldives and Bengal as well as Kugha (Africa) that were important trading centres in trans-Saharan and trans-continental trading routes.[51] Tom Pires, the Portuguese ambassador to China, arrived in India in 1511 and described the cowrie trade links between the Malabar, Calicut, Coromandel Coast, Bengal, Orissa, Pegu, Martaban and Arakan. There was a degree of local variation in the values of cowries; in the markets of Bengal, around 448 cowries could get a good chicken, while the cost it was about 400-500 cowries in Martaban in Arakan. Cowries also functioned

47 Cowries are small shells used as monetary exchange. They were of small monetary denomination in the order of value in relation to the metal coins like copper, silver and gold. Bengal cowries were larger in size with yellow stripes in the middle, whereas white cowries were found in Pegu, Arakan, Siam and Malacca. They were widely prevalent as not only medium of exchange, but also valued as desirable possession of power and wealth. Usually rich people hoarded large quantities of cowries.

48 Yang Bin, "Horses Silver, Cowries;" Yang Bin, "The Bengal Connections in Yunnan." *China Report* 48/1-2 (2012): 125-45.

49 H.U. Vogel, "Cowry Trade and Its Role in the Economy of Yunnan: From the Ninth to the Mid-Seventeenth Century (Part I)." *Journal of Economic and Social History of the Orient* 36/3 (1993): 211-52.

50 J. Heimann, "Small Changes and Ballast: Cowry Trade and Usage as an Example of Indian Ocean Economic History." *South Asia* 3/1 (1980): 48-69.

51 Ibn Battuta, *Travels in Asia and Africa, 1325-1354* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1983, First edition, 1929).

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library



MAP 2 Circulation of "cowries"

as currency in the kingdom of Chiang Mai (northern Thailand), and in Borneo and Malacca.[52] The early seventeenth-century French sailor, Francois Pyrard mentioned that ships loaded with cowries went to Bengal where there was a high demand. In the same vein, Marco Polo (though his account is of course, much earlier) also confirms the usage of cowries in the region.[53] Besides usage as currency, cowries were treasured and stored by the rich and still form a part of cultural practices in eastern India. Though an unstable medium of exchange (mass production was possible with farming; it was sometimes also brittle and could be destroyed much more easily that the metal coins), their popularity of use encompasses the outward stretch of the "Southern Silk Road."

3 Restructuring Routes: The Colonial Phase

The arrival of colonial rule brought about a rupture in the flow and continuity of trade and networks, and resulted in the reorganization of political and economic fortunes of Asia. Geographical linkages, human mobilities and their relationship with the environment changed with new institutions, technologies and infrastructure reshaping the identities of places. Among the Europeans

52 Interestingly, the eastern part of Siam did not use this currency. Tom Pires accounts as taken from Yang Bin, "The Bengal Connections in Yunnan": 128-129.

53 P. Pelliot, *Notes on Marco Polo, Vol. 1* (Paris, 1959).

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

powers with footprints in Bengal, the Portuguese had established a factory in Bandel, built strong connections in the Arakan region with shared interest with the local powers in the slave trade, and also dominated over Chittagong. The Dutch (Serampore) and the French (Chandernagore) made territorial annexations, but were later overshadowed by the British East India Company. Warren Hastings, realizing the importance of the existing trade links for the British, took the initiative to send four political missions to Bhutan and Tibet in the 1770s[54] to seek permissions for trade. He wrote to the Court of Directors (4 April 1771):

> ... the Company may be greatly benefited in the sale of broadcloth, iron and lead and other European commodities by sending proper persons to reside in Rungapore to explore the interest of parts of Bhutan ...[55]

It is interesting to note that the then ruler of Coochbehar, Deb Raja, allowed only non-European merchants to freely pass through his kingdom to carry on trade between Bengal and Tibet.[56] Deb Raja's policy helped the Bhutanese merchants and traders to enjoy trade privileges and the rights to sell their horses in different parts of Bengal. They enjoyed exclusive trading privileges in sandal, tobacco, betel nuts and leaves, indigo, and otter skins, while other merchants were prohibited from importing these items into Bhutan.[57] The British initiated efforts to encourage trade through numerous trade fairs. Bogle, who headed the political mission to Bhutan sent by Warren Hastings in 1774, introduced one in Rangpur in 1780; D. Campbell (the first Superintendent of Darjeeling) started fairs in Titaliya, Phalakata (Jalpaiguri district) and the Alipur.[58] Large number of traders from Nepal, Tibet, Bhutan and Sikkim participated in the fairs. In this phase of collaboration, the fairs helped British promote their goods and advance Anglo-Bhutanese relations, and brought about stability in the region.

The scenario changed after British annexation of the Assam and Bengal Duars (which means "doors" in local language; explained later) in the mid-nineteenth century (1841-65). Assam emerged with new importance in the British strategic map with the tea plantation industry, particularly around the time when the East India Company lost its monopoly rights in 1833.

54 The British missions were headed by Bogle in 1774, Hamilton in 1776 and 1777, and Turner in 1783, see P. Collister, *Bhutan and the British* (London: Serindia Publications, 1987)

55 Ibid.: 8.

56 S. Gupta, *British Relations with Bhutan*, (Jaipur: Panchsheel Prakashan, 1974): 46-47.

57 W.K. Firminger ed. *Bengal District Records, Rangpur, 1770-1779*, Volume I (Calcutta, 1920): 47.

58 W.W. Hunter, *A Statistical Account of Bengal* (London: Trubner & Co., 1876): 270, 297.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

The Bhutanese trade suffered due to the annexation, thus the indigenous Mechis surviving on the trade with Bhutan, faced the economic backlash, scarcity and famines. The Sinchula treaty of mutual friendship between Bhutan and the British signed in 1865 was violated in some provisions by Lord William Bentinck, who discontinued the granting of transit rights for leaders of the trade caravans from Bhutan to Dinajpur and Rangpur[59] or free accommodation of the Bhutanese traders in the market places.

Shifting of river systems in the Bengal delta and the downfall of the kingdom of Pegu (1757) and the continuing Arakanese-Portuguese-driven pirate raids since the seventeenth century led to the eventual downfall of the thriving trade, political and cultural links in the region. The nodal importance of medieval Bengal's deltaic ports and commercial centres had been already on the wane. The British further imposed boundaries to segregate the land and its people from the earlier networks through a new grid of systems. Whether it was the new land tenure system that drew apart the cultivators and the owners of the land through the Permanent Settlement, or the commercialization of agriculture through cultivation of jute, indigo, sugar by luring or coercive methods, the imagination of land and respective emotional attachments shaped through different interest groups that emerged, like the *zamindars* (owners of land), and the landless cultivators thus leading to new ideas of "place-making." The flourish of the globally acclaimed Bengal textiles soon succumbed to the machinations of the colonial order.[60] The plantation and mining industries like tea, coal and oil in Bengal and Assam introduced new methods of commerce, human displacement and land exploitation. The Indian sub-continent's economy became intimately tied to the global economy and was driven by it. The profits were steered towards the East India Company's coffers, thus reversing the advantageous bullion trade and autonomous economic structure hitherto enjoyed in the region.

Colonial rulers overwhelmed the Asian continent with their technological advancements and new inventions from Europe. The introduction of railways, telegraphs and steamships spurred communication links to British advantage. Thus, the volume of India's trade with China in the eastern Indian frontier through Burma (which was much less throughout the nineteenth century than that between India and China's eastern coast) increased by about

59 D.F. Rennie, *Bhotan and the Story of the Dooar War* (New Delhi: Manjushri Publishing House, 1970): 159-60.

60 Om Prakash has made a detailed research on the flourish and demand for Bengal textiles and how they fell into the hands of the colonial order, see Om Prakash, *Bullion for Goods: European and Indian Merchants in the Indian Ocean, 1500-1800* (New Delhi: Manohar, 2004).

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

30 percent between 1896 and 1899. The British realized the strategic importance of Bengal and accelerated the commercial exploitations in eastern belt of India through tea, coal and jute facilitated their economic projects and made Calcutta (at present, renamed Kolkata) one of the most important commercial centres of the British Empire. Chittagong port was also developed to link the rich jute-producing Narayanganj region as well as creating alternate routes from Assam. British developments in Assam through commercial production of tea and coal, and the construction of Eastern Bengal Railway line (built in 1885, and connecting Comilla, Dhaka, Chandpur, Chittagong, and linking the hinterland to the ports of Bay of Bengal), led to increased commercial activities and mobilities and revitalized the proposal of trade links between India and Myanmar, and possibly with plans of extending it to Yunnan eventually.

In 1765, right after the victory at Buxar, the first Surveyor General of India, James Rennell, was entrusted to find the shortest route connecting eastern India through the Ganges waterway to the Calcutta port, indicating British long-term commercial and political strategies. Rennell "discovered" the Brahmaputra, the first ever European to do so, and pointed out that Yunnan was just 220 miles away from the river.[61] Similar insight was shared by Arthur Cotton (1860s), who argued that the shortest distance between the Brahmaputra and Yangtze rivers was 250 miles. At a conference in 1899, the Associated Chambers of Commerce, representing about 70 chambers of commerce in Britain recommended that Chittagong should be connected with Calcutta in the West and with the Mandalay-Rangoon Railway in the east.[62] With increasing geopolitical concerns[63] the British government, by 1904, agreed to construct a number of routes connecting Bengal, the Northeastern frontier, Burma and China. One political reason was "well-strategised" Partition of Bengal that was executed in 1905 by Curzon where parallel options of railways, inland navigational routes were created for Calcutta (west) and Chittagong (east) in a divided Bengal. The other reason was the larger apprehensions arising out of emergence of a strong Japan and its assertive foreign policies after the Russo-Japanese victory and French designs to push into the western frontiers of Yunnan.

With strategic motivations to make political inroads into Tibet, the British sought to establish relations with the Dalai Lama there. In 1903, Lord Curzon's Younghusband Mission to Tibet resulted in Anglo-Tibetan Convention of 1904,

61 I. Iqbal, "The Space between Nation and Empire: The Making and Unmaking of Eastern Bengal and Assam Province, 1905-1911." *The Journal of Asian Studies* 74/1 (2015): 72.

62 Ibid.: 73-74.

63 There were apprehensions and emerging political realities of Russia and France taking control of eastern parts of China and pushing them to the western frontier of Yunnan.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

whereby trade was promoted between Tibet and Bengal but Tibetans were required to destroy all forts along Indo-Tibet border.[64] Even though older trade interactions received a major setback with new participants in trade and commerce, the British occupation of Tibet and new treaties carved out fresh possibilities of trade expansion in the region. By the early 20th century, several trade firms had emerged in Yunnan exclusively engaged in commodity trade between Yunnan and Bengal, northeast India, Tibet and Burma. They used long existing land routes, but also made use of the Yunnan-Burma and India-Burma railways and road link.[65] A description of one such trading firm, Hengshenggong in Yunnan sheds light on the circulation of trade in the entire region.

> Hengshenggong set up branches in Calcutta and Kalimpong, established tea processing factory in Menghai (Yunnan), and tea was freighted to border towns of Burma and further taken to Rangoon by train, from there to Calcutta by sea and further to Siliguri by train. Trucks took those commodities from Siliguri to Kalimpong and then to Tibet … and sold in Lhasa. The firm made purchases in Tibet for medicinal material and other local products as well as wool and freighted them to India. The wool was sold in India, other commodities were transported by sea and sold in Shanghai.[66]

The British further explored new routes to China during Japanese aggression in the Second World War with concerns of imperial expansion of Russia and their souring relations with China. Thus the regions of Bhutan, Nepal and Tibet were posited to act as buffer states in case of any foreign incursions. An important road that was built in 1942 when the Japanese cut off the Burma Road was the Ledo Road (later, the Stilwell Road) that connected Ledo, Assam to Kunming, China passing through Myanmar (Shingbwiyang, Myitkyana and Bhamo in Kachin state). (The route was closed down in the post-colonial period, but is being revived at present.) Thus, the centrality of Bengal that began to be transformed into a peripheral identity in political discourse since the shift of the seat of governance to Delhi in 1912 continued into the later decades with the creation of frontier/ buffer states and new borders, which had serious repercussions in post-colonial state formations and identities of peoples and places.

64 R. Sarkar and I. Ray, "Political Scenario in Bhutan": 14.

65 Ren Zia, et al. "Research on Yunnan-India Local Trade." In *The Southern Silk Route: Historical Links and Contemporary Convergences*, ed. L. Ghosh (New Delhi: Manohar, 2019): 334-39.

66 Ibid.: 339.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

4 The Transition: The Post-Colonial Period to the 21st Century

The trans-regional possibilities and the development of overland communication links between "Bengal" and China through Burma along the riverways and roadways faced major disruptions after the independence and Partition of India in 1947, which was soon followed by territorial disputes and the Sino-Indian conflict (1962) both on India's northern and eastern boundaries. Additionally, the emergence of a Communist China and over-looming threats of the Cold War created different tensions and conflicts in Asia and the world. Political boundaries erected huge walls of disconnect to the age-old well-established circulatory movements. The rising influence of nation-state centricism with political borders bore a strong legacy of the colonial schemes of redrawing frontiers (e.g., Mac Mohan Line, Radcliff Line) nurturing antipathy between communities and political entities. Within a few decades, China and India broke into conflicts[67] in contrast to the shared synergies of the "Asian" age. These states became inward looking, away from the maritime,[68] increasingly focusing on their respective territorial boundaries. The nationalist discourse that accelerated during the Cold War period became staunchly embedded into the political, socio-economic, and cultural agenda that effectively manifested in policy initiatives of nation-states, and in institutionalization of regional bodies like the ASEAN and SAARC.[69] In academia, it gave rise to departments on area studies and area-focused publishing houses that harped on insular solidarity and spirit of self-determination for states cutting across the Bay.[70] Thus, the "cowrie" connections were soon chapters of a forgotten history.

67 The Sino-Indian conflict of 1962 and territorial disputes at Aksai Chin (north-western India) and Arunachal Pradesh (north-eastern India) had been the main bone of connection between the two emerging global powers in the post-colonial period. It took more than 25 years to break the impasse and re-energize their relations when Indian Prime Minister, Rajiv Gandhi made a visit to China in 1988. The economic relations slowly gained momentum with bilateral trade reaching around $89 billion in 2017-18. However, recent border conflicts at Doklam (2017) and Galwan (2020) have been a major setback. India has started taking steps to restrict inflow of Chinese investments into the country. Anchal Magazine, Sunny Verma, 'Explained: How the new public procurement restrictions target China', *The Indian Express*, 26 July 2020, https://indianexpress.com/article/explained/india-public-procurement-restrictions-china-6522726/ accessed 26 July 2020.

68 In spite of extensive coastlines, neither India nor China emerged as big maritime powers in a post-colonial phase.

69 Regional institutions like ASEAN (Association of Southeast Asian Nations) formed in 1967, and SAARC (South Asian Association of Regional Cooperation) formed in 1985 facilitated to divide the Southeast Asian region with that of South Asia more markedly and fed into the regional demarcations of the Cold War period.

70 For further details on the transition refer to J. Bhattacharya, "The Sea of Changes: Shifting Trajectories Across the Bay of Bengal." *Asian Politics and Policy* 9/2 (2017): 245-67.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

The turn of the millennium brought about new geopolitical considerations, multilateral initiatives and a renewed attention to the maritime domain. The Eastern Indian Ocean Region, extending from the Himalayas to the "Pacific Rim" became the rising "arc of advantage"[71] incorporated in the emerging rhetoric of the "Indo-Pacific,"[72] bringing the Bay of Bengal to the forefront of Asian geopolitics. Increasing economic regionalism led to exploration of new possibilities of converging interests in the Bay mobilized by state-led foreign policy considerations, market-driven trajectories and human mobilities. India had promulgated its Look East Policy in the 1990s (later re-energized as Act East policy in 2014) in which its north-eastern "peripheral" or "borderland" states were brought into focus with the aim of rejuvenating their economy and carving out "new" land-routes to South-east Asia. It coincided as a hedging strategy in counterbalancing growing Chinese footsteps in the region. On the other hand, China incorporated the trope of the ancient Silk Road revival with a sharp focus in the Bay of Bengal/ Indian Ocean Region (IOR) where the proposed land and sea routes would meet. The traditional frontier regions like Yunnan were brought into the forefront of policy and academic discourses, aligning several interest groups like BIMSTEC (explained later), thus, creating the "necessary fulcrum for fresh knowledge production with strategic and economic imperatives."[73]

Big State Led Projects

The Chinese concept of Silk Road Economic Belt and the 21st-century Maritime Silk Road proposals [or Belt and Road Initiatives (BRI)], initiated by their President, Xi Jinping, in 2013[74] is a powerful strategic discourse that contin-

71 For further discussion on this, refer to Anindyo J. Majumdar, "Contemporary Security Scenario in the Eastern Indian Ocean Region: The Efficacy of Contingent Realism." In *Eastern Indian Ocean: Historical Links to Contemporary Convergences*, ed. Lipi Ghosh (Newcastle upon Tyne: Cambridge Scholars Publishing, 2011): 100-115.

72 Indo-Pacific, a new term coined in international relations to signify the growing proximity of several Asian states (India, Australia, Japan as prominent powers) and the US in the Bay of Bengal and the South China sea to mutually cooperate and resist the expanding footsteps of China in the maritime domain. The United States describes the geopolitical essence of the term as "an ironclad and enduring commitment to a region" between the Pacific Ocean and the Indian sub-continent. Leigh Hartman, 'What is the US Indo-Pacific Strategy?' *Share America* (23 September 2019) https://share.america.gov/what-is-u-s-indo-pacific-strategy/ accessed 25 July2020.

73 Bhattacharya, "Sea of Changes": 249.

74 President Xi first made the proposal public during his visits to Kazakhstan and Indonesia in September-October 2013. The Chinese strategy proposed to link up new and old rail and road routes between Central Asia and Western China, and also connecting maritime routes from the Pacific coastal cities of China through the Indian Ocean region to the

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

ues to be debated and critiqued on many fronts. It has accelerated economic development for lesser-developed peripheral regions of China and several other states along BRI routes to promote efficient sea-trade connectivity, boost infrastructure, create new ports and refurbish others, and develop economic zones/ hinterlands, thus boosting trade and connectivity for all participants in the project. In the Bay, Chinese investments have poured into Myanmar, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka. In China's domestic context, the BRI project would address the industrial overcapacity and rising production costs, and also help shift low-end manufacturing industries to the developing economic zones of the MSR partners.[75]

Unlike the grand and global scale of Xi's masterstroke foreign policy, India initiated a more regional Look East Policy (LEP) much earlier in 1990, focusing mainly on the lesser-developed northeastern region and proposing to extend linkages with Southeast Asia. Scholars have characterized Indian foreign policy as comprising "spheres of influence of concentric circles,"[76] as can be observed in the shift from South Asia to Southeast Asia, and recently, to the Indo-Pacific. LEP was initiated by the Indian Prime Minister, Narasimha Rao.,[77] and carried forward by his successor, Vajpayee, who introduced the idea of a Car Rally in 2004, using soft power approach to explore new land routes and rejuvenate the old ones. On assuming power in 2014, PM Narendra Modi elevated LEP to Act East Policy at the East Asia Summit in Nay Pyi Daw

Mediterranean. The Maritime Silk Road (MSR) begins in Fujian province and through Guangdong, Guangxi, Hainan lead to the Malacca Straits into Kuala Lumpur and then into the Bay of Bengal connecting with Chittagong, Colombo and into Nairobi in the IOR.

75 G.S. Khurana, "Geopolitics of China's 'Maritime Silk Road' Concept: An Indian Perspective." In *China's Maritime Silk Road and Asia*, ed. V. Sakhuja and J. Chan (Delhi: Nation Maritime Foundation, Vij Books India Pte Ltd, 2016): 2.

76 B. Gaens and O. Ruohomäki "India's 'Look East'- 'Act East' Policy: Hedging as a Foreign Policy Tool." *The Finnish Institute of International Affairs* (*FIIA*) *Briefing Paper* 222 (June 2017): 4.

77 India's Look East Policy (LEP) was first announced by the then Prime Minister Narasimha Rao in Singapore in the 1990s, which was followed with a positive momentum by the succeeding Indian Prime Ministers irrespective of their different ideological inclinations in political thinking. In the initial years, defense cooperation and closer economic investments were carried out with India's Southeast Asian neighbours like Singapore and Malaysia. LEP received a new boost with the Indian P.M. Vajpayee's floating the idea of a car rally through the northeastern states into Southeast Asia, which was materialized in 2004. The idea was to explore the land routes through the region, which not only became successful but was repeated again in 2012 with visions of integration, shrinking distances and promoting regional cooperation.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

in 2014.[78] The focus now extended to the entire Indo-Pacific region "at the very top of … diplomatic priorities."[79] Unlike China's one-man-driven policy, LEP/AEP evolved and reached out from Southeast Asia to Far Eastern states through different generations of Indian leadership, who continued to nurture the idea with additional steps forward.

Multilateral Groupings in the Bay

Along with the emerging giant powers in the region, different multilateral groupings with alternate or complementary trajectories have emerged in the Bay. The Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC)[80] has been formed to bring together neighbouring nations "lying in the littoral and adjacent areas of the Bay of Bengal constituting a contiguous regional unity" which can play the role of "a platform for intra-regional cooperation between SAARC and ASEAN members."[81] Some projects promoted through BIMSTEC include the Kaladan Multimodal project,[82] the Asian Trilateral Highway connecting India and Thailand through Myanmar,[83] and the pact for the movement of goods and vehicles among Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal (BBIN). From the Indian point of view, BIMSTEC represents a multilateral tool to pursue stronger connectivity and economic partnerships between its northeast region and the eastern neighbours.[84] AEP has produced a proliferation of strategic and security initiatives with ASEAN

78 https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/look-east-policy-now-turned-into-act-east-policy-modi/article6595186.ece accessed 12.10.2018

79 I. Saint-Mézar, "India's Act East policy: Strategic implications for the Indian Ocean." *Journal of the Indian Ocean Region* 12/2 (2016): 179.

80 BIMSTEC was born in 1997 as 'BIST-EC' (Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka and Thailand Economic Cooperation), and is defined as a sector-driven sub-regional cooperative. The organisation now includes five members from South Asia (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal, Sri Lanka) and two from Southeast Asia (Myanmar and Thailand).

81 "Overview | BIMSTEC." Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation. Accessed April 02, 2018. http://bimstec.org

82 The Kaladan Multimodal project seeks to link India and Myanmar, connecting Kolkata to Sittwe, and then to Mizoram by river and road. The framework agreement between India and Myanmar had been signed in 2008.

83 The Asian Trilateral highway will run from Moreh in Manipur to Mae Sot in Thailand via Myanmar and represents a significant step in establishing connectivity and boosting trade between India and Southeast Asian countries. The project is under implementation.

84 Rubul Patgiri, and Obja Borah Hazarika. "Locating Northeast in India's Neighbourhood Policy: Transnational Solutions to the Problems of a Periphery." *India Quarterly* 72/3 (2016): 235-49.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

involving the littoral countries of the Bay of Bengal including ReCAAP,[85] Milan exercises,[86] and the Shangri-La Dialogue.[87]

The Bangladesh-China-Myanmar-India (BCIM)[88] grouping has interestingly brought China and India together in the same geographical space to carve out new economic corridors to promote their peripheral regions. The region, comprising 40% of the world population and 9% of the world's total area, has increasingly gained political prominence with state leaders. In a significant move, the Chinese premier Li Keqiang proposed the construction of the BCIM corridor to his Indian counterpart, Manmohan Singh at New Delhi (18 May 2013) that was promptly reciprocated by India.[89] Myanmar and Bangladesh responded with similar positivity. A government-sponsored K2K (Kolkata to Kunming) Car Rally (February 2013), covering about 3000 km, showcased the potential of the proposed 2800 km corridor that would connect

85 ReCAAP or Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia is a multilateral agreement concluded in November 2004 and entered into force in September 2006. It includes Australia, Bangladesh, Brunei, Cambodia, China, Denmark, India, Japan, South Korea, Laos, Myanmar, Netherlands, Norway, Philippines, Singapore, Sri Lanka, Thailand, United Kingdom, United States and Vietnam. ("About | ReCAAP ISC." ReCAAP Information Sharing Centre. Accessed April 02, 2018. http://www.recaap.org/about_ReCAAP-ISC.)

86 MILAN has been organised as multilateral friendship naval exercises in the Bay of Bengal. For further insights, refer to David Scott, "The great power 'Great Game' between India and China: 'The logic of geography'." *Geopolitics* 13/1 (2008): 1-26.

87 The IISS Asia Security Summit: The Shangri-La Dialogue" (SLD), is an inter-governmental security forum hosted annually since 2002 by the International Institute for Strategic Studies (IISS), featuring defense ministers, Prime ministers and Army heads of 28 Asia-Pacific and some other Western states. These are: Australia, Brunei, Cambodia, Canada, Chile, China, France, Germany, India, Indonesia, Japan, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, Mongolia, New Zealand, Pakistan, Philippines, Russia, South Korea, Sri Lanka, Singapore, Sweden, Thailand, East Timor, United Kingdom, United States and Vietnam. It is also known as Shangri La Dialogue after the name of the hotel where it takes place annually in Singapore. The keynote speaker of the 2018 IISS SLD was India's Prime Minister Narendra Modi. ("IISS." *International Institute for Strategic Studies*. Accessed April 02, 2018. https://www.iiss.org/).

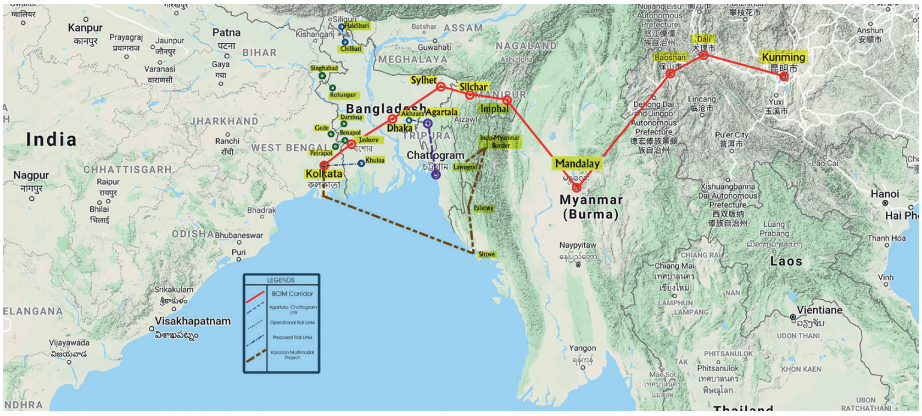
88 Chinese scholars in Yunnan first conceived the idea of Bangladesh- China- Myanmar-India (BCIM) Economic Corridor (BCIM-EC) at the end of the 1990s in what was known as the "Kunming Initiative". It converted into BCIM Forum for Regional Cooperation with its first meeting in 1999, which identified specific sectors and projects to strengthen cooperation and institutional arrangements between participants and stakeholders. The Forum was a Track II exercise by scholars, business leaders, technical experts, think tanks, tourism officials. However, it gained momentum with India's LEP and China's Western Region Development Strategy and eventually converted to a Track-I coordination involving government officials.

89 Rupak Bhattacharya, "The Emerging Bangladesh China Indian Myanmar- Economic Corridor and its opportunities." *The Eastern Today*, 11 February 2016.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

China's Yunnan province with Kolkata, passing through Yangon-Mandalay in Myanmar, Chittagong-Dhaka-Sylhet in Bangladesh, and Manipur in Northeastern India. A similar ancient route was the shortest one between India and western China serving as a highway for Chinese merchants from the 12th to 16th centuries.

A positive discourse on the possibilities of the BCIM proposal has emerged in academia, think tanks and government narratives. However, when compared to China's trade with Bangladesh, India and Myanmar that increased from US$ 30 billion in 2006 to US$ 82 billion in 2012, India's share in this trade increased from a modest US$ 7 billion in 2006 to US$ 36 billion in 2012.[90] The BCIM intra-regional trade among members amounted to 5 percent only of total BCIM trade in 2012, whereas the corresponding figure for intra-regional trade within ASEAN was 35 per cent.[91] BCIM could have been "a game changer that South Asia needs(ed),"[92] with the possibilities of upgrading of the 312 km stretch of Stilwell Road connecting Northeast India with Yunnan through Myanmar and reducing 30 per cent of transportation costs, or Yunnan and West Bengal cooperating in agro-processing sectors. But the fact that India is not part of BRI has arguably impeded the success of BCIM.



MAP 3 Proposed routes and renewed engagements

90 Indra Nath Mukherji and Subrata Kumar Behra, "India's Trade and Investment with BCIM Countries." In *BCIM Economic Corridor: The Road Ahead,* ed. Rajiv K Bhatia and Rahul Mishra (New Delhi: Indian Council of World Affairs, Pentagon Press, 2015): 26.

91 Pravakar Sahoo and Abhirup Bhunia, "BCIM Corridor a game changer for South Asian trade." *East Asia Forum*, 18 July, 2014, http://www.eastasiaforum.org/2014/07/18/bcim-corridor-a-game-changer-for-south-asian-trade/ accessed 9.12.2016.

92 Ibid.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

The rhetoric of the South Silk Road has become an inevitable part of political, policy and academic dialogue[93] rethinking ancient Yunnan-Myanmar-India connections through old routes, local trade and human interactions that had never ceased to exist. There is an inclination to open up markets to alleviate the economic condition of the "frontier" regions that had succumbed to the marginalization of the peripheral states and closed-door nationalistic policies. The "frontier" identity persists; however, cross-border political and economic engagements have reinstituted the significance of this "Zomian" space extending into the Bay of Bengal. While "Bengal" is not visible in the ensuing dialogue for the simple reason of its divided boundaries, the constant references to Bengal's position as a nodal point in the circularity of India-China relations across the Bay of Bengal direct our attention to this geographical space without doubt.

In these circumstances of contestations and collaborations, both Myanmar,[94] a connector to India-China, and Bangladesh,[95] another important state in the north of the Bay, are being enticed for different projects both by China and India. As a counterpart to China's MSR project, India has been

93 One such dialogue has been initiated as 'Yunnan-India Local Trade Project' started by a group of scholars from the Institute for South Asian Studies at Yunnan Academy of Social Sciences. The Ford Foundation (2000-2003) has funded it. Ren Zia, et al. "Research on Yunnan-India Local Trade": 301-72.

94 India started the Mizoram-Myanmar Kaladan Road, a $484 million project that also converges with the Sittwe port in the Rakhine, where China had initiated a lot of investments. Pratim Ranjan Bose, "India starts construction of Rs. 1000-cr Mizoram-Myanmar Kaladan Road." *The Hindu Business Line*, 17 April 2018, https://www.thehindubusinessline.com/news/india-starts-construction-of-1600-cr-mizoram-myanmar-kaladan-road/article23577107.ece accessed 3.6.2019. China, on the other hand, has signed the China-Myanmar Economic Corridor project with Myanmar in September 2018 as part of its BRI initiative. This corridor will connect Kunming, Yangon, Mandalay with lesser tariffs and formation of joint industrial roads. Chan Jia Hao and Deepakshi Rawat, "China's Digital Silk Road: The Integration of Myanmar." *RSIS Commentary* 084 (29 April 2019). There have been hiccups for the Chinese as well, see R. Zhang, "Chinese investments in Myanmar: Beyond Myitsone Dam." *The Diplomat* 22 July 2020, https://thediplomat.com/2020/07/chinese-investment-in-myanmar-beyond-myitsone-dam/ accessed 28 July 2020. Thus contestations between India and China in Myanmar are quite visible and facilitating opportunities of development for Myanmar.

95 Bangladesh has become the new focus for India-China rivalry, each trying to gain a better foothold on the space that had been a traditional ally of India. China and Bangladesh became strategic partners in 2016; China is also the largest trading partner to the fastest growing economy of South Asia. For further discussion, refer to A. Riaz, "As the Sino-Indian rivalry heats up, watch Bangladesh carefully." *Atlantic Council*, 2 July 2020, https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/blogs/new-atlanticist/as-the-sino-indian-rivalry-heats-up-watch-bangladesh-carefully/accessed 28 July 2020.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

rapidly boosting its naval assets—a course of action that presents a scenario of contestations rather than cooperation in the region. With both the rising powers aiming to chalk out alternate routes and revive older connections to gain legitimacy for their acts, the other states in the region are drawn into the strategic disagreement. Indian strategists tend to identify the Chinese infrastructural investments surrounding India as a security threat, maintaining that the development of port infrastructure across the IOR which China promotes through the MSR has potential for military development.[96] Beijing has continued with a containment policy towards India as Mohan Malik pointed out: "90 per cent of China's arms sales go to countries that border India."[97] The Bay is emerging as a theatre for possible encounters, with unsure surrounding states, desiring to counterbalance China with positive relations with India, while at the same time being in receipt of large-scale Chinese investments.

Conclusion: Making Sense of "Place-Making"

The northern Bay of Bengal has emerged with new analytical paradigms of knowledge production facilitated by economic globalization, the search for new markets and marine resources, and the rebranding of emerging global powers. Different hierarchies have emerged as a result of prosperity and politics of routes under state promotion, sponsorship and patronage, sources of commodities and their distribution channels, and also out of ecological shifts and their effects on human transactions. Maritime routes, perhaps, have maintained better stability in their continuity, though remain subject to the governance and interests of individual states. The Bengal delta still remains as the centre of negotiations, with Ganges-Brahmaputra-Meghna basin emerging as an important space for contestations and collaborations over shared water between India, Bangladesh and China amongst other things. It is also through West Bengal's "chicken-neck" Siliguri corridor[98] that the northeastern

96 Zhu Li, "The Maritime Silk Road and India: The Challenge of Overcoming Cognitive Divergence." *Asia Policy* 22/1 (2016): 20-26.

97 B.R. Nayar and T.V. Paul, *India in the World Order* (New Delhi: Cambridge University Press, 2013): 217.

98 This narrow strip of the Siliguri corridor has been in the news due to its strategic significance in connecting the maritime Bengal delta with the Northeast, Sikkim and Bhutan. It has been argued that China's face-off with India in the Doklam plateau (2018) in Bhutan (near Sikkim) had been aimed to shorten distance for Chinese army to target the vulnerable Siliguri corridor. Shaurya Karanbir Gurung, "Beyond China's Sikkim's aggression, a plan to isolate Northeast from rest of India." *The Economic Times*, 12 July 2018, https://

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

region of India connects the sub-Himalayan tracts to the maritime; this route could be very significant to the AEP. With advancement of technologies, the hierarchies of routes have attained a different magnitude of operations creating reconstructed identities of space and networking. Thus, while there is an emerging discourse to counter "methodological nationalism"[99] with digital roads, cable networks,[100] air connectivities and other virtual networks, there is a major departure from the prevailing synergies of earlier "episodic histories". The declining enthusiasm surrounding the Nathu La Pass in Sikkim that was opened in 2006 for prospects of trade between India and China but was more symbolic than economically effective, is an example of how re-thinking overland trade route linkages could not be worked out successfully with political, infrastructural and other challenges.[101] In a major departure from the past, particularly since 1962, two power blocs are driving strategic collaborations, emphasizing connectivities and rethinking historical linkages, yet avoiding convergences and escalating political tension that has transformed a peaceful, prosperous space to one full of apprehensions and contestations.

The cognitive understanding of the spatial networks across the Bengal delta-Himalayan belt can be further exemplified with communication corridors that spread into the Himalayan mountain belt north of the Brahmaputra basin into Bhutan, analogous with the Terai region in southern Nepal, and were known as the "Dooars" or "Duars." "Duar" in Bengali, Assamese, Maithili and some other languages, translates as door in English. Controlled by the Koch dynasty of the Kamata kingdom, followed by the Bhutanese kingdom, until the British annexed in 1865, the region corresponds to Jalpaiguri and Cooch Behar districts of West Bengal and Goalpara, Dhubri, Kokrajhar, Barpeta districts in

economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/defence/border-face-off-why-china-tries-to-break-chickens-neck-to-isolate-northeast/articleshow/5 accessed 29 July 2020.

99 Willem van Schendel & Erik de Maaker, "Asian Borderands: Introducing their Permeability, Strategic Uses and Meanings." *Journal of Borderland Studies* 21/1 (2014): 3-9. The emerging study on Asian Borderlands, as discussed earlier, is a significant attempt to understand social dynamics in broad regional fields.

100 MOUs between China and 16 countries have been signed under digital Silk Road (DSR). Since 2018, Myanmar's Ministry of Transport and Communication has been working with China's Huawei (present in Myanmar since 2013) to deploy 5G broadband services across Myanmar in the next five years. Similarly, the China-Myanmar International cable system was launched in 2014. Chan Jia Hao and Deepakshi Rawat, "China's Digital Silk Road."

101 A detailed discussion on the Nathu La Trade Study Group is done in Pramesh Chettri, "India-China Border Trade Through Nathu La Pass: Prospects and Impediments." *Himalaya* 38/1 (2018): 11-22. Haraprasad Ray also discusses the differences in trade trends in the highways to the Chinese market from northern Bengal, Sikkim and Himachal Pradesh in *Trade and Trade Routes between India and China, c.140 B.C.-A.D. 1500* (Kolkata: Progressive Publishers, 2003): 99-100.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

Assam. The "duars," conduits of commercial and cultural exchanges which led to Bhutan, were eighteen in number, and took their names from the different passes in the hills.[102] Eleven of the Bengal duars touched upon the northern frontier of Bengal, between the rivers Teesta and Manas. The other seven, the Assam duars, lay between the rivers Manas and Dhansiri. The area is now home to many wild life sanctuaries and national parks (Jaldapara, Gorumara, Buxa, Chapramari, Mahananda Wild Life Sanctuary) and is promoted by both state governments and non-government agencies as an important tourist attraction and preservation of the grasslands and forest areas in the region. This is a complete change of the economic model that prevailed in a pre-colonial period that had well-connected trade routes for important commodities between Bengal, Kamrupa (Assam), Nepal, Bhutan and Tibet. Thus, the identity of this unique grassland ecology transformed from the gateway of economic exchanges (the "door", *duar*) to one that promoted tourism and state preservation of large stretches of flora and fauna, posited as "borderlands" on the fringes of different political boundaries. *Duar* was thus transformed into a metaphor for peripheral borderland.

My argument on the emphasis on highlighting the centrality of the "Bengal delta" overlaps with the circulatory land routes and waterways in this space. Several flourishing nodal points or junctures fed into the larger regional and global circulatory networks.[103] There were nodes that connected different ecosystems, nodes that emerged as a result of state patronage, nodes that formed parts of new geopolitical encounters. Chittagong, for example, forms an important link point for both BRI and other multilateral projects, thus emerging as a space for both accommodation and encounter in different geopolitical agendas, an important centre in trans-regional and global economic circulations. The new phase of internationalization is often intermixed with fragmentation and disruption along with spreading out and speeding up, a phenomenon that Doreen Massey refers to "time-space compressions" in post-modern societies, inspired by Marxist idea of "the annihilation of space by time."[104] While it may be helpful in making sense of a place in a more progressive manner, rather

102 For details of the *duars* or routes between Bengal and Bhutan, refer to see Ratna Sarkar and Indrajit Roy, "Two Nineteenth Century Trade Routes in the Eastern Himalayas: The Bhutanese Trade with Tibet and Bengal." *Journal of Bhutan Studies* 15 (Winter 2006): 73-74.

103 Amongst other scholars, Markovits, Pouchepadass and Subrahmanyam contextualise the circulation theory in their publication. See, C. Markovits, J. Pouchepadass and S. Subrahmanyam, *Mobile People and Itinerant Cultures in South Asia, 1750-1950* (Delhi: Anthem Press, 2003).

104 D. Massey, "A Global Sense of Space." *Marxism Today* (June 1991): 24-29.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

than being "defensive" and "self-enclosing," the imagination of a place is often punctuated with heavy-handedness of nation-centric policy discourses.

Broad historical trajectories have been conveniently utilized to frame politico-strategic ideologies and foreign policy relations by some states in the 21st century. The tactical marketing of such ideologies has been incorporated in globalization flows and a liberalized market economy, thus successful attempts to a considerable extent were made to synergize multilateral interests, security initiatives, economic collaborations and compulsions under a single state-driven policy framework. Thus the "Silk Route," which at no point in history was a single route, nor a static one, got appropriated and disseminated as one dominating path connecting the Mediterranean with the South China Sea through the BRI project, in an assertive display of hegemonic political ideology. The South and Southeast Asian communication channels and trade corridors have been pushed as a peripheral construct in such a strategic discourse. The Look East or the Act East Policy (AEP) reasserts the peripherality of the landscape and the identity of the space in an attempt of political re-thinking and possible economic re-construction of a neglected region through the lenses of centrally driven political agenda of the nation-state. This state-driven effort has undoubtedly activated political/academic rethinking, revival of ancient routes, communication links, and community interactions in discourses across the region, thus arousing deeper exploration into historical continuities and disruptions. The success of the multilateral regional bodies may lead to reconsideration of this space through alternative lenses of situating and invoking the centrality of the region in human mobilities and commercial, cultural and religious exchanges beyond transnational and trans-regional boundaries. However, there is a prevalent disconnect between the policy initiatives of different states and a nuanced historical understanding of spaces and communities affected by recent policy changes. This has been starkly visible not only in emerging polarizing trends and tussles between the rising Asian powers, but also in several instances of human displacements, forced mobilities, and erecting walls of disengagements between overlapping ethnic-religious communities. While policy makers become active participants in creating new geo-political narratives, they have neglected nuanced comprehension of historical flows. Some states have effectively fashioned this based on chosen historical facts, legends, mythologies leading to glorified national fervors. History has been utilized as and when necessary, skewed for the benefits of soft diplomacy, and marketed to create and sustain the euphoria of grand strategies. A geopolitically imposed interpretation of historical construct may not be synergized with the framework for understanding the evolving global

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

cultural economy, which is no more confined to centre-periphery model, but has accelerated a complex, disjunctive order, as Appadurai suggests, in exploring different dimensions of global flows.[105] In contemplating alternative dialogue to heavily loaded infrastructure-led economic compulsions and contestations, there may be strong possibilities of accommodating the continuum and cultural synergies to create cosmopolitan heritage sites in which multiple stakeholders are integrated with long-term effects.

Bibliography

Amrith, Sunil S. 2013. *Crossing the Bay of Bengal: The Furies of Nature and Fortunes of Migrants*. Cambridge, Mass: Harvard University Press.

Appadurai, Arjun. 1990. Disjunctures and Differences in the Global Cultural Economy. *Theory, Culture and Society* 7: 295-310.

Battuta, Ibn. 1983. *Travels in Asia and Africa, 1325-1354*. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul. First edition, 1929.

Bayly, C.A. 1983. *Rulers, Townsmen and Bazaars: North Indian Society in the Age of British Expansion, 1770-1870*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Bayly, C.A. 1990. Indigenous Social Formations and the "World System": North India since c. 1700. In *South Asia and World Capitalism*, ed. Sugata Bose. Delhi: Oxford University Press: 112-139.

Borah, Abikal. 2014. A Region in a Mobile World: Integration of Southeastern Himalayan Region into the Global Capitalist Economy (1820-1900). *Review* (*Fernand Braudel Center*) 37/2: 87-127.

Bhattacharya, Jayati. 2011. *Beyond the Myth: Indian Business Communities in Singapore*. Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies.

Bhattacharya, Jayati. 2017. The Sea of Changes: Shifting Trajectories Across the Bay of Bengal. *Asian Politics and Policy* 9/2: 245-267.

Bhattacharya, Jayati. 2019. Connectivity Across Colonial Bay of Bengal in the 19th and 20th Centuries. In *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Asian History*, ed. David Ludden. New York: Oxford University Press. oxfordre.com/asianhistory.

Bhattacharya, Rupak. 11 February 2016. The Emerging Bangladesh China Indian Myanmar- Economic Corridor and its opportunities. *The Eastern Today*.

105 Appadurai explores five dimensions of study for the global flows—ethnoscapes, mediascapes, technoscapes, financescapes and ideoscapes, see A. Appadurai, "Disjunctures and Differences in the Global Cultural Economy." *Theory, Culture and Society* 7 (1990): 296.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

Bhattacharya (Chakraborti), Swapna. 2002. Myth and History of Bengali Identity in Arakan. In *The Maritime Frontier of Burma: Exploring Political, Cultural and Commercial Interaction in the Indian Ocean World, 1200-1800*, ed. Jos Gommans and Jacques Leider. Leiden: Koninklijke Nederlandse Akademie van Wetenschappen, KILTV Press: 199-212.

Bose, Pratim Ranjan. 17 April 2018. India starts construction of Rs. 1000-cr Mizoram-Myanmar Kaladan Road. *The Hindu Business Line*. https://www.thehindubusinessline.com/news/india-starts-construction-of-1600-cr-mizoram-myanmar-kaladan-road/article23577107.ece accessed 3.6.2019.

Bose, Sugata. 2006. *A Hundred Horizons: The Indian Ocean in the Age of the Global Empire*. Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press.

Braudel, Fernand. 2009. History and the Social Sciences—The Longue Durée (translated by Immanuel Wallerstein), *Review* (*Fernand Braudel Center*) 32/2: 171-203.

Chakravarti, Ranabir. 1999. Early Medieval Bengal and the Trade in Horses: A Note. *Journal of Economic and Social History of the Orient* 42/2: 194-211.

Chan Jia Hao and Deepakshi Rawat. 29 April 2019. China's Digital Silk Road: The Integration of Myanmar. *RSIS Commentary* 084.

Chatterji, Joya. February 1999. The Fashioning of a Frontier: The Radcliffe Line and Bengal's Border Landscape, 1947-52. *Modern Asian Studies* 33/1: 185-242.

Chettri, Pramesh. 2018. India-China Border Trade Through Nathu La Pass: Prospects and Impediments. *Himalaya* 38/1: 11-22.

Collister, Peter. 1987. *Bhutan and the British*. London: Serindia Publications.

Dale, Stephen F. 2009. Silk Road, Cotton Road or…. Indo-Chinese Trade in Pre-European Times. *Modern Asian Studies* 43/1: 79-88.

Eaton, Richard Maxwell. 1993. *The Rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier, 1204-1760* Berkeley: University of California Press.

Firminger, W.K., ed. 1920. *Bengal District Records, Rangpur, 1770-1779*, Volume I, Calcutta.

Gaens, Bart and Olli Ruohomäki. June 2017. India's "Look East"- "Act East" Policy: Hedging as a Foreign Policy Tool. *The Finnish Institute of International Affairs* (*FIIA*) *Briefing Paper* 222: 1-7.

Ghosh, Lipi. 2019. *The Southern Silk Route: Historical Links and Contemporary Convergences*. New Delhi: Manohar.

Ghosh, Lipi. 1994. *Burma: Myth of French Intrigue*. Calcutta: Naya Udyog.

Green, Nile. 2012. *Making Space: Sufis and Settlers in Early Modern India*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Gupta, S. 1974. *British Relations with Bhutan*. Jaipur: Panchsheel Prakashan.

Gurung, Shaurya Karanbir. 12 July 2018. Beyond China's Sikkim's aggression, a plan to isolate Northeast from rest of India. *The Economic Times*. https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/defence/border-face-off-why-china-tries-to-break-chickens-neck-to-isolate-northeast/articleshow/5 accessed 29 July 2020.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

Ispahani, Mahnaz Z. 1989. *Roads and Rivals: The Political Uses of Access in the Borderlands of Asia*. Ithaca and London: Cornell University Press.

Khurana, Gurpreet S. 2016. Geopolitics of China's „Maritime Silk Road" Concept: An Indian Perspective. In *China's Maritime Silk Road and Asia*, ed. Vijay Sakhuja and Jane Chan. Delhi: Nation Maritime Foundation, Vij Books India Pte Ltd.

Hall, Kenneth R. 2010. Ports-of-Trade, Maritime Diasporas, and Networks of Trade and Cultural Integration in the Bay of Bengal Region of the Indian Ocean: c. 1300-1500. *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 53/1-2: 109-145.

Hartman, Leigh. 23 September 2019. What is the US Indo-Pacific Strategy? *Share America*. https://share.america.gov/what-is-u-s-indo-pacific-strategy/ accessed 25 July 2020.

Heimann, James. 1980. Small Changes and Ballast: Cowry Trade and Usage as an Example of Indian Ocean Economic History. *South Asia* 3/1: 48-69.

Hunter, W.W. 1876. *A Statistical Account of Bengal*. London: Trübner & Co.

Hussain, Syed Ejaz. 2013. Silver Flow and Horse Supply to Sultanate Bengal with Special Reference to Trans-Himalayan Trade (13th-16th centuries). *Journal of Economic and Social History of the Orient* 56/2: 264-308.

Iqbal, Iftekhar. 2015. The Space between Nation and Empire: The Making and Unmaking of Eastern Bengal and Assam Province, 1905-1911. *The Journal of Asian Studies* 74/1: 69-84.

Levebvre, Henry. 1991. *The Production of Space* (Translated by D. Nicholson-Smith). Oxford, Cambridge: Blackwell Publishing.

Ludden, David. 2019. "India's Spatial History in the Brahmaputra-Meghna River Basin." In *Landscape, Culture and Belonging: Writing the History of Northeast India*, ed. Neeladri Bhattacharya and Joy Pachuau. Cambridge, New York: Cambridge University Press: 23-37.

Ludden, David. 1990. World Economy and Village India, 1600-1900: Exploring the Agrarian History of Capitalism. In *South Asia and World Capitalism*, ed. Sugata Bose. Delhi: Oxford University Press: 159-177.

Magazine, Aanchal and Sunny Verma. 26 July 2020. Explained: How the new public procurement restrictions target China. *The Indian Express*, https://indianexpress.com/article/explained/india-public-procurement-restrictions-china-6522726/ retrieved 26 July 2020

Majumdar, Anindyo J. 2011. Contemporary Security Scenario in the Eastern Indian Ocean Region: The Efficacy of Contingent Realism. In *Eastern Indian Ocean: Historical Links to Contemporary Convergences* ed. Lipi Ghosh. Newcastle upon Tyne: Cambridge Scholars Publishing: 100-15.

Markovits, Claude, Jacques Pouchepadass and Sanjay Subrahmanyam. 2003. *Mobile People and Itinerant Cultures in South Asia, 1750-1950*. Delhi: Anthem Press.

Massey, Doreen. June 1991. A Global Sense of Space. *Marxism Today*. 24-29.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

Mazumdar, R.C. 1976. *History of Bengal*, Volume-1. Dacca: University of Dacca.

Mukherji, Indra Nath and Subrata Kumar Behra. 2015. India's Trade and Investment with BCIM Countries. In *BCIM Economic Corridor: The Road Ahead*, eds. Rajiv K Bhatia and Rahul Mishra. New Delhi: Indian Council of World Affairs, Pentagon Press: 25-61.

Mukherjee, Rila. November 2008. Putting the Rafts Out to the Sea: Talking of "Bera Bhashan" in Bengal. *Transforming Cultures eJournal* 3/2: 124-144.

Nayar, Baldev Raj and T.V. Paul. 2013. *India in the World Order*. New Delhi: Cambridge University Press.

Patgiri, Rubul and Obja Borah Hazarika. 2016. Locating Northeast in India's Neighbourhood Policy: Transnational Solutions to the Problems of a Periphery. *India Quarterly* 72/3: 235-49.

Pelliot, Paul. 1959. *Notes on Marco Polo, Vol. 1*. Paris: Imprimerie Nationale.

Prakash, Om. 2004. *Bullion for Goods: European and Indian Merchants in the Indian Ocean, 1500-1800*. New Delhi: Manohar.

Ramachandran, Sudha. 22 July 2019. How Bangladesh Learned to Love the Belt and Road. *The Diplomat*. https://thediplomat.com/2019/07/how-bangladesh-learned-to-love-the-belt-and-road/ accessed 14 July 2020.

Ray, Haraprasad. 2019. Southern Silk Route: A Perspective. In *The Southern Silk Route: Historical Links and Contemporary Convergences* ed. Lipi Ghosh. New Delhi: Manohar: 29-35.

Ray, Haraprasad. 2003. *Trade and Trade Routes between India and China, c. 140 B.C.-A.D. 1500*. Kolkata: Progressive Publishers.

Ren Jia, et al. 2019. Research on Yunnan-India Local Trade. In *The Southern Silk Route: Historical Links and Contemporary Convergences* ed. Lipi Ghosh. New Delhi: Manohar: 301-72.

Rennie, David Field. 1970. *Bhotan and the Story of the Dooar War*. New Delhi: Manjushri Publishing House.

Riaz, Ali. 2 July 2020. As the Sino-Indian rivalry heats up, watch Bangladesh carefully. *Atlantic Council*. https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/blogs/new-atlanticist/as-the-sino-indian-rivalry-heats-up-watch-bangladesh-carefully/ accessed 28 July 2020.

Roy, Tirthankar. November 2011. Where is Bengal? Situating an Indian Region in the Early Modern Period. *Past and Present* 213: 115-146.

Sahoo, Pravakar and Abhirup Bhunia. 18 July, 2014. BCIM Corridor a game changer for South Asian trade. *East Asia Forum*. http://www.eastasiaforum.org/2014/07/18/bcim-corridor-a-game-changer-for-south-asian-trade/ accessed 9.12.2016.

Saint-Mézard, Isabelle. 2016. India's Act East policy: Strategic implications for the Indian Ocean. *Journal of the Indian Ocean Region* 12/2:177-90.

Sarkar, Ratna and Indrajit Roy. Winter 2006. Two Nineteenth Century Trade Routes in the Eastern Himalayas: The Bhutanese Trade with Tibet and Bengal. *Journal of Bhutan Studies* 15: 56-83.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

Sarkar, Ratna and Indrajit Roy. Winter 2007. Political Scenario in Bhutan during 1774-1906: An Impact Analysis on Trade and Commerce. *Journal of Bhutan Studies* 17: 1-20.

Schendel, Willem van. 2002. Geographies of Knowing, Geographies of Ignorance: Jumping Scale in Southeast Asia. *Environment and Planning D: Society and Space* 20: 647-68.

Schendel, Willem van. 2005. *The Bengal Borderland: Beyond State and Nation in South Asia*. London: Anthem Press.

Schendel, Willem van. 2015. Spatial Moments: Chittagong in Four Scenes. In *Asia Inside Out: Connected Places*, ed. Eric Tagliacozzo, Helen F. Siu and Peter C. Perdue. Cambridge, Mass: Harvard University Press: 98-127.

Schendel, Willem van & Erik de Maaker. 2014. Asian Borderlands: Introducing their Permeability, Strategic Uses and Meanings. *Journal of Borderland Studies* 21/1: 3-9.

Scott, David. 2008. The Great Power „Great Game" between India and China: „The Logic of Geography". *Geopolitics* 13/1: 1-26.

Scott, James C. 2009. *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Sen, Jahar. 1977. *Indo-Nepal Trade in the Nineteenth Century*. Calcutta: Firma KLM Private Limited.

Sen, Tansen. 2006. The Formation of Chinese Maritime Networks to Southern Asia, 1200-1450. Maritime Diasporas in the Indian Ocean and East and Southeast Asia (960-1775). *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 49/4: 421-453.

Sen, Tansen and Victor H. Mair. 2012. *Traditional China in Asian and World History*. Ann Arbor: Association of Asian Studies.

Vogel, Hans Ulrich. 1993. Cowry Trade and Its Role in the Economy of Yunnan: From the Ninth to the Mid-Seventeenth Century (Part I). *Journal of Economic and Social History of the Orient* 36/3: 211-252.

Waugh, Daniel C. 2010. The Silk Roads in History. *Expedition* 52/3: 9-22. https://www.penn.museum/sites/expedition/the-silk-roads-in-history/.

Wallerstein, Immanuel M. 1983. *Historical Capitalism*. London: Verso.

Wallerstein, Immanuel M. 1990. Systems Analysis and Historical Particularity: Some Comments. In *South Asia and World Capitalism* ed. Sugata Bose. Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Wallerstein, Immanuel M. 2004. *World-Systems Analysis: An Introduction*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Wang Bangwei, and Tansen Sen compiled. 2011. *India and China: Interactions through Buddhism and Diplomacy—A Collection of Essays by Professor Prabodh Chandra Bagchi*. New Delhi: Anthem Press.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library

Washbrook, David A. 1990. South Asia, World System and World Capitalism. *Journal of Asian Studies* 49/3: 479-508.

Yang, Bin. September 2004. Horses Silver, Cowries: Yunnan in Global Perspective. *Journal of World History* 15/3: 281-322.

Yang, Bin. 2009. *Between Winds and Clouds: The Making of Yunnan* (*Second Century BCE to Twentieth Century CE*). New York: Columbia University Press.

Yang, Bin. 2012. The Bengal Connections in Yunnan. *China Report* 48/1-2: 125-45.

Zhang, Ruosui. 22 July 2020. Chinese investments in Myanmar: Beyond Myitsone Dam. *The Diplomat*. https://thediplomat.com/2020/07/chinese-investment-in-myanmar-beyond-myitsone-dam/ accessed 28 July 2020.

Zhu Li. 2016. The Maritime Silk Road and India: The Challenge of Overcoming Cognitive Divergence. *Asia Policy* 22/1: 20-26.

Downloaded from Brill.com06/22/2021 07:48:20AM
via National University of Singapore - YNC Library